

LOCKER OBJECT TREATMENT: THE ASHES •

2026-09-08

Fresh Fable agent, no tools, same nine-station brief as the clock treatment, differing only in the object. Filed verbatim so Stephen can see how it plays before ruling. Working sketch, not prose for the game; nothing here is approved.

1.

The forged letter's paragraph:

"I have put Mum in here with this. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Nobody takes her anywhere until this is sorted. Keep her at whichever house you read this in, where all four of you can see her."

The starter-list line:

"Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat. I said no both times. He did not ask why, and I did not say."

2.

Ruby opens the padlock because her key is out first. The letter is on the shelf in a plastic sleeve. Next to it, upright, the tube.

Margo speaks first. "She's brought her mum." Her hands go into her coat pockets and stay there.

Brad looks at the sleeve, not the tube. He reaches past it, takes the letter and hands it to Ruby unopened.

Liam does not look at anything else. His hand is round the middle of it the way you'd lift a flask, and he stops with it an inch off the shelf and looks at Ruby.

"It goes where the letter goes," Ruby says. "Mine."

Liam nods and carries it out to her car. He puts it in the footwell, not the boot, because the boot has her work bag in it. Nobody says anything about that, and Brad locks the cupboard.

3.

It lives on the sideboard in Ruby's kitchen, beside the folder with the letter and the four notebooks, the label turned to the wall because that is how Liam set it down and nobody has turned it since. Nobody decided. Ruby said "mine" at the locker and meant the letter, and the tube followed the letter the way a bag follows a coat. At the second meeting Liam asks whether she ought to go back to the house. Margo says the sister has the house keys now and is clearing it at her own pace. Ruby says she stays, and picks up the next notebook, and that is the decision. The sister is not told.

4.

Ruby reads the list again, one line at a time, and they take them in order. Margo has the notebook open at Liam's page because it is his turn; they have done Brad and Ruby.

"March and July," Ruby reads. "Liam, is that right?"

"March and July."

"Why twice?" Margo asks. "She'd said no."

"Because it had been four years. I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one who decided."

Brad says, "That's Liam. He'd have thought that." He says it to the table, gently.

Margo writes something. "She put it on the list, though. So it bothered her."

"Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her," Ruby says.

Nobody looks at the sideboard.

"When were you last in the back bedroom?" Margo asks. Not sharp. It is the next line on her page.

Liam thinks about it honestly, which is the worst thing he can do. "I sat up there with her mum the last week. Since then, once. Vi asked me to look at the window catch. Spring, maybe."

"This spring?"

"I think so."

Brad says, "That catch has been bad for years." Helping.

Ruby closes the notebook. "Right. Next line."

But it is not next line. Margo has written Spring and underlined it, and Ruby has seen her do it, and Liam has seen Ruby see.

He says, "I wanted her off that shelf. That's the whole of it. I'll not ask again, now she's at Ruby's anyway."

5.

One beat, and it costs nothing if it stays in the hands. Week six, before Brad drives out. Margo is early at Ruby's and Ruby is upstairs on the phone. Margo stands at the sideboard with her coat still on. She has spent that week reading the letter for the thing it does not say, and this is the only thing in the room the letter does talk about. She turns the tube a quarter so the label faces out. She looks at it for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs. Then she turns it back the way it was, because she is not the one who set it down, and sits at the table. Ruby comes in and finds her writing. Nothing is said, nothing changes, no figure enters Margo's head or the page. It costs nothing because the reader takes it as a woman declining to touch a decision that was not hers, and only on the second read as the evening she stopped trusting the room. Cut it if the day-77 message feels like it needs to stand alone; it can.

6.

Ruby, in her kitchen, with the sideboard behind her and nothing on it:

"There was a letter and there was something of hers beside it. I'll tell you the letter, most of it, when I'm ready. I won't tell you what was beside it."

"Because it points at someone?"

"Because it doesn't. It's nothing to do with any of this. She put it there for us to mind, and I'm still minding it, and you don't get to put it in an episode with music under it. Ask me anything about the letter. Don't ask me that again."

Then, standing, "And don't ask Liam. He'll tell you, and he'll hate that he did."

The shape of it is custody, not secrecy: she refuses on the grounds that the thing is hers to look after, denies it is evidence, and in warning Ally off Liam tells her both that Liam would talk and that the thing weighs on him.

Ally learns anyway, from absence. She goes to the sister for background on Violet, and the sister, still clearing the house room by room, says the only thing she wanted out of it was their mother, and she was not on the shelf. She assumed Violet had finally taken her out to the point and was a little angry not to have been asked. Ally does not correct her. Later Tessa's screenshot arrives, "the thing in the cupboard is wrong," and Ally already knows what the cupboard is and what stood in it. She never has it confirmed by Ruby. She does not need to.

7.

It was never Violet putting her mother behind a padlock. It was Brad carrying her mother out of the house on the night he left her daughter at the foot of the stairs, and choosing her, out of everything in that house, to stand beside his letter so that the one man who had ever asked for her would be the one the room looked at. The tube never pointed at Liam. Brad did, and used her to do it.

Liam says, "He handed Ruby the letter and let me be the one who reached." And after a while, "I carried her to the car for him."

8.

Ruby telephones the sister, and the sister asks Liam, so that this time it is not Liam asking. On a flat morning the three of them take the boat out. Ruby carries the tube down the slip the way she would carry anything and sets it on the thwart. At the point the sister gets the lid off and cannot do the rest, so Liam does it, over the side and downwind, the way Violet said she would when she could face it. The sister keeps the empty tube and puts it in her bag. Nobody says anything on the way in.

9.

The most dangerous break: Brad takes the tube on the night of the killing, hours before his note tells him a locker exists, so either he already knew about the notes, which the fixed timeline denies, or he carried a dead woman's mother out of her house for no reason he yet had, and nothing in the brief supplies one.

Second: ashes are the loudest object available, and every scene at that table wants someone to look at the sideboard and say something, so the no-description and no-grief-theatre rules are under pressure across nine scenes rather than one, and a single lapse turns the book sentimental.

Third: the room arrives at Liam through a kindness, a man who wanted to help his friend scatter her mother, and it only holds because the window-catch admission and the starter-list line lean on each other, which is two coincidences doing the work of one motive and risks the reader thinking less of Ruby and Margo rather than more of Brad.

I would ship it on one condition: give Brad a plain on-the-night reason for the tube that is not the frame (she had it in her hands on the stairs, and a tube at the foot of the stairs is a question a coroner asks), so that its use beside the forgery becomes a forger's improvisation the next day rather than a plan he could not yet have had.